Arabian Leopard Friends

Reem

and the Story That Grew

A small question. A lifelong passion.



A Holiday with No Signal



Reem: Even my messages are on holiday!

I thought visiting Grandma in southern Saudi Arabia meant three things: a long drive, endless food and a phone signal that vanished whenever I needed it. In my notebook I wrote: "Holiday plan: survive boredom." I had no idea the mountains outside held a story that would change my plans.

A Guest in a Story



Grandma: A story starts a question; it does not finish the research.

After dinner, Grandma pointed towards the mountain. People here had passed down stories about the Arabian leopard: quiet-footed and rarely seen. Was it a magical hero? "A real animal," she laughed. "But imagination can grow inside a story." For once, I forgot to look for my phone.

A Leopard in the Margin



Reem: Drawing requires practice. And a very large eraser.

I drew curious eyes, a long tail and little rosettes. My first attempt looked like our cat after a huge dinner. The second was slightly better. I called my imaginary leopard "the mountain's neighbour". I knew he lived in my imagination. I had never met him outside Grandma's door.

A Leap of Imagination

Before sleep, I imagined him stepping across rocks and disappearing into their colours. In my imagination I was just as graceful. In real life I tripped over my bag on the way to get water. How did he live there? What did he eat? My complaints page became a list of questions.



One Bar Is a Beginning



One bar of signal appeared in the morning. I held up my phone like a trophy. Search results offered different pictures, claims and numbers. Before copying the first result, I remembered Grandma. Who wrote this? When? What evidence did they use? Research was harder than holding a phone in the air.

Detective Reem's File



Mum helped me find reliable scientific information about the Arabian leopard. I organised my notes: fact, source, date. This animal faced a serious threat and needed sustained conservation. I did not invent a number or turn every dramatic headline into a fact.

Rosettes, Not Stripes



Imaginary tiger: Has anyone seen my book?

I sent my friend a leopard drawing. She sent back a tiger. We compared trusted photographs: a tiger has stripes; an Arabian leopard has rosettes. I fixed my drawings and added a tiger with a note: "Wrong story." We laughed, but now we could explain the difference.

A Map Is Not the Whole Story

I drew mountains in my notebook. My teacher explained an important difference: historical range and places with confirmed current evidence. A beautiful picture on a map proves very little. I left a question open instead of pretending certainty. My notebook became smarter when I wrote: "We need more evidence."



An Adventure with Rules



On an educational walk with an adult and a guide, we found tracks beside the permitted trail. I was ready to announce the discovery of the century. The guide explained that a track alone may not identify its maker. We stayed on the trail. "Reem discovers a leopard" became "Reem learns to observe."

The Patient Camera



Reem: My hardest job so far: waiting.

The guide explained how field cameras help specialists observe animals without chasing them. I liked this patient camera that never asked a leopard to smile. I imagined my mountain neighbour walking just beyond my picture. Sometimes the best observation begins by giving an animal space.

Not Alone in the Story



At school I drew plants, a herbivore and a leopard, then connected them. "I thought this was about one animal!" said a classmate. Food, habitat, water and people were all part of the picture. We put our drawing on the board. My notebook neighbour had become a whole-class conversation.

Bigger Than a Poster

We planned a school campaign with colours and a giant slogan. Our teacher asked: "What do you want people to do?" We chose a clear message: learn from trustworthy sources, respect wildlife and share accurate information. Our corner had a story, questions and sources visitors could check for themselves.



Correcting Is Not Losing



One sentence in our poster exaggerated the evidence. I hoped nobody would notice; we had already printed copies. Then I remembered why we were doing this. We corrected it and added a source. The world did not collapse. A classmate asked me how to check her own research. Our mistake became a useful lesson.

Dreams Come with Homework



Reem: Enthusiasm is wonderful. It does not replace studying.

I grew older, but my mountain neighbour stayed in my notebooks. Conservation was not a day-long wildlife photo session. It involved science, maths, writing and teamwork. When statistics confused me, I wrote: "The leopard will not do my homework." I asked for help and began to understand how numbers could answer real questions.

Many Photos, More Questions



Years later, I studied science and trained with a specialist team. I reviewed field-camera photographs and recorded observations. Most were not dramatic discoveries: a rock, a shadow, an animal passing quickly. Careful data came from repeated small observations. Even "nothing recorded" needed thoughtful interpretation.

More Than One Hero

I worked alongside a researcher, a veterinarian, a ranger, a communicator and people who knew the landscape well. Each knew things I did not. I used to imagine saving the leopard alone. Now I understood teamwork. I listened carefully, asked clearer questions and followed "I do not know" with a plan to find out.



The Day the Plan Changed



During field training, conditions changed. We did not continue just because a route was on our plan, and nobody took a risk for a photograph. We reviewed the information together. I felt disappointed, then understood that a responsible decision can mean stopping or waiting. Conservation does not need reckless heroics.

My First Day at Work



After study and training came my first day on an Arabian leopard conservation team. On my desk were a map, a task list and an old notebook from Grandma's house. I had not received a magic wand. I had a responsibility: gather evidence carefully, work with others and help people understand why it mattered.

A Picture Worth Waiting For



During a monitoring project in a known leopard area in Oman, specialists checked a camera record before making any announcement. I studied the rosettes, the tail and the quiet step. It was not the end of conservation work, but a reminder that monitoring mattered. My mountain neighbour was real. Our work had to be real too.

This Time, I Tell the Story

Back at Grandma's, we opened the first page: "Holiday plan: survive boredom." We laughed. Then I told the younger children about the Arabian leopard. "What can I do?" one girl asked. "Begin with a question. Find a trustworthy answer. Share what you learn." In her bag I noticed a brand-new notebook.

Grandma: It seems the story has found another notebook.



“Holiday plan: survive boredom.”

That was Reem’s plan when she arrived at Grandma’s house. Then a story about the Arabian leopard changed everything. Her notebook filled with drawings and questions, and an ordinary holiday became the start of an unexpected journey.

Through mountain stories, research and discovery, Reem learns that caring about one animal can lead to protecting a whole world.

Open the notebook. Follow Reem’s story.

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